

Success, succeed, successful, successfully

Teaching guide

Use the correct member of a word family.

Understand the distinction

Success is a noun: The event was a success. Succeed is a verb: We succeeded. Successful is an adjective: The event was successful. Successfully is an adverb: We completed it successfully.

Use succeed in + -ing for achieving an action: succeed in finding a solution. Not every noun use needs an article: hard work can contribute to success. Describe what the success means instead of relying only on a positive label.

Compare the patterns

NOUN

The event was a success.

A success names a successful event.

VERB

We succeeded in finding a room.

In is followed by an -ing form.

ADVERB

We booked the room successfully.

Successfully modifies booked.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Complete: The project was ____ . (success / successful)

- A. successful
- B. successfully
- C. success

2. Complete: We succeeded in ____ the problem. (solve)

- A. solve
- B. to solve
- C. solving

3. Choose the adverb: success / successful / successfully

- A. successfully
- B. success
- C. successful

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which pair uses the success word family correctly to describe an achievement?

- A. We successfully organized the meeting. It was a success because everyone could join.
- B. We successful organized the meeting. It was a success.
- C. We successfully organized the meeting. It was a successfully.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. A. successful

An adjective describes the project.

B: Successfully is an adverb; was needs successful or a success here.

C: Without an article, this position needs successful; a success is another valid pattern.

2. C. solving

Use -ing after in.

A: After in, use the -ing form solving.

B: Use succeeded in solving, not in to solve.

3. A. successfully

The adverb can describe how an action was completed.

B: Success is a noun, not an adverb.

C: Successful is an adjective; successfully is the adverb.

4. A. We successfully organized the meeting. It was a success because everyone could join.

Successfully modifies organized; a success is a noun phrase.

B: Use the adverb successfully to modify organized.

C: After a, use the noun success rather than the adverb.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-34.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Which pair uses the success word family correctly to describe an achievement?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.